

TALES OF THE HOPTEC: SOLARUS

by
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Act One

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EXT. HIGHWAY - DAWN

SUPER : 2015

The pink and orange hues of the Sunrise paint the sky in the desert as a lonely highway is quite busy. A gas truck fire is being put out as fire fighters and cops look at a sedan burnt to a crisp.

COP

How is it possible?

FIRE FIGHTER

It's a miracle.

COP

It's something.

Inside the car is NICK GUERRERO 16, he is unharmed, holding the burnt skeleton of a woman. He is inconsolably weeping.

FIRE FIGHTER

What do you suppose happens to a kid like that?

The sun comes into full view behind the mountains

EXT. GAS STATION - NIGHT

SUPER: PRESENT DAY

NICK 38, but seems much older, wakes up behind the thick glass of a gas station mini mart. He sees a woman SHAY, 23, run over to the glass. She looks fearful. She pounds on the glass.

SHAY

Let me in! Please!

Nick motions for her to walk to the door.

INT. GAS STATION - NIGHT

Nick leaves his booth to meet her. She runs inside and closes the door and looks for the lock.

NICK

Oh, do we have to lock that door?

SHAY

What?

NICK

I'm not overly fond of locked doors.

She has a look of absolute terror. Nick sees two guys CHAD and DERRICK mid 20's, running across the street as they slow to a walk.

DERRICK

We got her.

Nick walks to a back room, he comes out with a bat, and a crow bar. He hands her the crow bar.

NICK

Does your phone have juice?

She grabs her phone and checks.

SHAY

I have 10%.

Chad runs jumps and kicks the door. Nick gives her his phone and a card. She nods.

NICK

Call the cops, the address is on the card.

NICK (cont'd)

I'm getting fired.

EXT. GAS STATION (REAR)- NIGHT

Nick shuts and locks the door.

EXT. GAS STATION - NIGHT

He walks around the building with a bat.

NICK

I've called the cops.

CHAD

You might as well let us in there.

Nick turns to the guys.

NICK

This is needless. The Police are on the way.

Derrick runs up and throws a trash can at the door.

DERRICK
This doesn't concern you old man.

NICK
No means No.

DERRICK
Not if we spent 300 dollars on
drinks!

NICK
That feels like more of a capitalist
thing.

CHAD
Let us in.

Chad picks up another trash can and crushes the door. Shay screams. Nick steps out of the way and picks up the bat in a swinging position. Chad and Derrick look at each other and start laughing.

NICK
Don't do that again.

Chad fake lunges at Nick as Nick swings. Derrick tackles Nick and starts to punch Nick in the face while Chad is kicking him.

CHAD
You had to be a tough guy! Just
couldn't be cool.

Shay opens the door and runs outside swinging the crowbar wildly and tries to stop them. Chad gets hit and turns.

CHAD (cont'd)
You got it coming now bitch!

Nick covers up as best he can as Derrick picks up the bat and just before he swings the sound of a shotgun being pumped is heard. Derrick turns around to see MARTY 35, aiming a rifle at him.

MARTY
Leave her alone pretty boy.

Nick looks at Shay, making eye contact through his blurry vision.

NICK
Get behind him.

Shay runs behind Marty.

CHAD

Easy pal.

MARTY

I'm not your Pal. Now step away from my friend.

DERRICK

What is with this gas station?

MARTY

Just move along.

Derrick spits on Nick as he walks past him. Chad punches him. Nick falls to the ground as Marty steps forward.

MARTY (cont'd)

HEY!

The sound of sirens is heard closing in.

CHAD

This isn't over.

Derrick trots away.

DERRICK

Come on.

Chad runs off as Nick passes out.

EXT. GAS STATION - JUST BEFORE DAWN

Everything looks fuzzy as Nick comes to. He sees a news van and an ambulance with Shay sitting in the back.

PARAMEDIC

(muted)

Sir. Sir. Are you okay?

Nick nods his head, and begins getting up and sees three cop cars, one with Chad and Derrick in the back. Nick rubs his eyes as a cop walking past him pats him on the back.

MARTY (O.C.)

Nicky!

Nick turns and sees Marty talking to OFFICER JACKSON 44, tall strong looking, very fit, calls Nick over. Nick walks over.

OFFICER JACKSON

(to Marty)

He was lucky you showed up.

Nick gets to them while a paramedic slides a blood pressure cuff on him. Nick stops and looks at the paramedic. The officer waves the paramedic off. The paramedic slides off the cuff.

PARAMEDIC

I'm just trying to do my job man.

The paramedic walks away.

NICK

Thanks.

OFFICER JACKSON

No problem. Not a lot of guys would have gotten involved, but do yourself a favor.

NICK

What's that?

OFFICER JACKSON

Save yourself. Not everyone is a hero. You can't change what you are?

Officer Jackson starts to walk away with Marty's shotgun.

OFFICER JACKSON (cont'd)

I need you guys to come down to the station this afternoon and pick this up, and make a statement.

The officers and paramedics drive away. The sun peeks over the mountains.

MARTY

Screw that cop. I bet you that girl is happy you tried to help her out.

LARRY WHITE 40's, the owner of the gas station walks over.

LARRY

You both are wrong. He who runs, lives.

MARTY

Whatever?

LARRY

You did good Nick. We are gong to get a ton of free publicity from this.

NICK

(confused)

You're welcome?

LARRY

Start your vacation early. Take three weeks. But I'm only paying for two.

NICK

Thanks?

Larry walks away over to the camera crew.

Marty watches Larry walk away pulls twenty bucks from his pocket and hands it to Nick.

MARTY

Pick up what you need to make breakfast.

Marty starts to walk to his car.

NICK

I don't need your money.

MARTY

Yeah you do. See you at breakfast.

Marty gets in his car.

MARTY (cont'd)

Hey. Get some sleep I don't want you groggy for the study.

NICK

How much does it pay?

MARTY

Enough to get your daddy-O a new chair.

INT. HOTEL ROOM - DAY

GENERAL SUTTON 64, strong jaw, with a smug look on his face sits at a desk looking through a series of papers. He grabs a phone and dials out. He walks out on a balcony.

EXT. BALCONY - DAY

Sutton sits down and lights a cigar. He looks at a paper.

GENERAL SUTTON
Margie, I'm gonna need Jack Macdonald
assigned to me and any weak spots in
the lab of Mallory Lee.

INT. HOUSE - DAY

FRANK, 72, is sitting in a wheel chair in front of a
television. Nick is preparing breakfast.

FRANK
What are you making?

NICK
Blueberry pancakes.

FRANK
Your Mom's specialty.

Frank wheels himself to a picture of Nick and his Mom,
halfway there the wheel sticks.

FRANK (cont'd)
Damn chair.

NICK
I'm working on getting you a new one.

FRANK
Son, it's too much money.

NICK
Pop, I can take care of it.

Frank picks up the picture, and gazes.

Nick pours some orange juice in a glass and walks over to
his dad handing him the juice. Frank reaches for a tissue
box as Nick walks back to the kitchen.

NICK (cont'd)
I miss her too.

Nick pours the batter onto the skillet. STEPHANIE 41, A
tomboy and Nick's older sister, hair in a ponytail, a little
bit sweaty from a workout comes walking into the kitchen.
She walks past Nick and slaps his ass and grabs a blueberry.

STEPH

Good game?

NICK

Thanks.

STEPH

Just don't burn the flap jacks Toots.

Al 45, bleary eyed, reeking of pot and Stephanie's boyfriend comes walking down the stairs.

AL

Good morning friends. Frank, how did you find your slumber?

FRANK

It was better than most.

AL

I had a dream of a banana riding a wave.

NICK

Were you the banana?

Al turns his attention back to Frank.

AL

Frank, do have the cure for what ails me?

FRANK

I have the government bag on my dresser.

AL

A little pre-breakfast bowl, would be God's work.

FRANK

Sounds good. It makes the food taste better.

Frank winks at his son. Al heads up the stairs. Marty comes walking in the front door.

MARTY

Smells good buddy. Good morning folks.

FRANK

Hey Marty.

MARTY

So what's Martha Stewart making for breakfast?

STACY

Blueberry pancakes.

Marty grimaces.

MARTY

I'll pick up a croissant on the way to the lab. Any other plans for the day?

FRANK

I completely intend on smoking a bowl before breakfast.

MARTY

Do you remember when you almost killed us for smoking oregano?

Nick shakes his head.

NICK

What time do you need me there?

MARTY

Ten.

NICK

How much?

MARTY

Why? You need to pay your dealer?

Nick fakes laughter.

NICK

Oh, that was a good one? I actually need to pay your Mom.

MARTY

Went for the Mom joke. You disappoint me. Oh yeah bring that paper saying you are a doofas at math.

Marty begins walking towards the door.

INT. LAB OFFICE- DAY

MALLORY LEE 38, her genius intellect is visibly taxed by the phone call she is on. She grabs her beaker filled with Coke and sips it as she paces by her desk.

MALLORY

John, I don't care how much money the football team brings in, I'm not going to sign off on a new stadium.

Marty softly knocks on her door holding a delivery slip.

MARTY

(whispers)

What do you want me to do with the solar panels?

Mallory points to the back of the lab. Marty looks where she points and nods.

MARTY (cont'd)

Thanks.

Marty motions for the delivery guy to follow him. Two guys with solar panels on hand trucks walk by the office door.

MALLORY

Do what ever you want... Fine send some tickets over.

Mallory hangs up the phone. Marty comes walking back.

MARTY

You okay boss?

MALLORY

Yeah I just hate the politics... Did you find our final subject?

MARTY

Yeah. Nick should finish our B group. Then we just compare the brain scans.

MALLORY

Good. He's not an idiot is he?

MARTY

Usually not, but you have a way of making men into bumbling fools.

MALLORY

Turning on the charm a little early aren't ya?

MARTY
Can you blame me?

Mallory slowly walks over to him and touches his chest. She leans in to him. In a sexy voice she says.

MALLORY
I have an eight year old.

MARTY
Please finish that sentence with
"bottle of whiskey".

Mallory shakes her head at him and walks into the lab.

INT. LAB - DAY

Mallory walks toward the center of the lab with Marty behind her.

MALLORY
Where is the subject?

MARTY
I told him to be here at ten.

JESSE 21, skinny and distracted walks briskly over to Mallory.

JESSE
Doctor. These results are coming
up... odd.

MALLORY
Remember what ever you are looking at
can be explained rationally.

JESSE
But-

MALLORY
Let's just watch it unfold. Some of
the greatest research has happened on
accident.

JESSE
Okay.

Jesse stands in front of Mallory as she looks at the file.

MALLORY
Yes?

JESSE
May I take off?

MALLORY
Get out of here.

Jesse walks to the back of the lab.

MALLORY (cont'd)
Study for your mid term instead of
working on that app.

Jesse nods and hangs his lab coat near the door. Nick walks
through the door and over to Marty.

NICK
Sorry I'm late.

MARTY
What took you so long?

NICK
Traffic.

Mallory walks over.

MALLORY
And you are?

NICK
Nick Guerrero. I'm here for the-

MALLORY
Fine. You'll do. You understand This
is a study to repair brain function
that lead to learning disabilities.

NICK
Yes.

MALLORY
You have proof of a learning
disability.

NICK
No, I was given this.

Nick hands over a card with a code.

MALLORY
Thank you, Anything else I need to
know?

NICK
I don't love enclosed spaces.

MALLORY
What?

MARTY
He has claustrophobia. But he can
keep it together for MRI's.

Marty nods at Nick aggressively who nods back.

NICK
Yeah, sliding through a compact metal
tube sounds fun.

MALLORY
Good... Marty.

Marty hops to it.

MARTY
Yeah, I know the drill.

MALLORY
I'll be in my office for twenty
minutes.

Mallory walks off. Nick follows her with his eyes.

MARTY
Come with me buddy.

Nick and Marty walk over to a testing room.

MARTY (cont'd)
Alright man, knock out the test on
computer test. Fill out the
application and someone will draw
some blood.

Marty looks up to see Nick locked on Mallory. Marty snaps
his fingers in front of Nick's face.

NICK
Oh, sorry.

MARTY
Stay focused. Plus she's got a kid.
Que se dice? Baggage.

NICK
Eres tonto.

MARTY
Me?...Anyway, blood draw, brain scan,
give you the B sample and Bob's your
uncle, you're out the door.

NICK
Thanks.

Nick sits down in front of the computer.

INT. EXAM ROOM - LATER

Marty is flicking a syringe. Nick has his eyes closed.

MARTY
You got the money?

NICK
Just inject me.

Marty injects him. The serum enters his blood stream and
heads toward his brain. Nick flinches.

MARTY
Needles make you nervous?

NICK
Only if they come out of your arm.

Nick blinks repeatedly.

MARTY
You okay?

NICK
Yeah fine. Just fuzzy headed.

Marty pats him on the back.

MARTY
I'll get you some water.

INT. HOTEL BAR - DAY

General Sutton sits at the bar with Jesse.

JESSE
So why am I here?

GENERAL SUTTON

I just need you to get a hold of the serum, and any information on side effects.

JESSE

For what you're paying, you got it.

Jesse leaves. General Sutton sips his drink. JACK MCDONALD 33, the guy who used to put people in lockers, walks in and sits next to General Sutton.

JACK

I just got my orders.

GENERAL SUTTON

And?

JACK

That's my-

GENERAL SUTTON

Alma mater. Listen your ex... whatever is running the study. I need you to be a distraction.

JACK

Permission to speak?

GENERAL SUTTON

Granted.

JACK

What do we need a learning disability study for?

GENERAL SUTTON

What's the major weakness in any soldier?

JACK

Sir?

GENERAL SUTTON

Questioning orders. I think this study can help on that department.

JACK

Mind control?

GENERAL SUTTON

No, more like suggestive influence... Does that pose a problem?

JACK

No sir.

GENERAL SUTTON

Then order yourself a drink
Captain... Good to have you on board.

INT. MAIN LAB -DAY

Mallory walks out of her office and sees Nick sitting in an exam room getting his blood pressure taken. She grabs the back of Marty's lab coat.

MALLORY

What is your buddy doing in exam room 2?

MARTY

His vitals.

MALLORY

Shouldn't he be doing a test?

MARTY

He's done. We did the brain scan and drew his blood already.

MALLORY

So soon.

MARTY

You were in there for more than twenty minutes.

MALLORY

Those are his second labs?

Mallory looks at Marty's info page.

MARTY

Yup. I brought the all star.

MALLORY

He never graduated from high School, that doesn't mean learning disabilities.

MARTY

Don't judge a book. Judger.

MALLORY

We can put him in the third category.

Nick comes walking out of the exam room, and over to Mallory.

MALLORY (cont'd)
So come back in two weeks, and we can
do another battery of tests and cut
you a check.

NICK
Thanks.

Nick extends his hand and Mallory shakes it. Their hands
shock each other.

MALLORY
That's just the mixture of you
rubbing against your clothes and the
low humidity of the lab.

NICK
Okay.

Nick walks away. One of the techs walks over with the phone
and hands it to Mallory. She removes her earring and takes
the phone.

MALLORY
Yeah... Okay I'll be right out.

Mallory heads for the door. Marty sees her.

MARTY
You alright?

MALLORY
Yeah, my daughter may be trying to
hug a tree outside.

MARTY
Is that some kind of environmental
thing?

EXT. GRASSY COMMON AREA-DAY

KAREN 8, is looking at a tree with her arms extended towards
it.

MALLORY
Karen, honey what are you doing?

A stuffed cat comes flying down into Karen's arms. This
startles Mallory. Nick comes bounding out of the tree. This
really startles Mallory.

NICK

There you go.

Nick sees Mallory.

NICK (cont'd)

Hi.

MALLORY

Oh, it's you.

NICK

It's me.

Karen opens her arms. Nick's takes a knee, as Karen hugs him.

MALLORY

Karen and I thank you.

NICK

No problem. Is she?

MALLORY

She's not much of a talker.

Nick smiles and nods he lifts his hand to Karen who gives him a high five.

NICK

So long.

Nick walks away as Mallory watches him. Karen tugs at her coat.

MALLORY

Lets go back to your class honey.

EXT. DESERT - NIGHT

Two silhouetted figures SHAMAN AHOTE 42 and LIVIA 35, a are shown with a star filled sky behind them.

SHAMAN AHOTE

Livia, I don't think you understand.
He is the warrior child.

INT. LIVING ROOM -NIGHT

Nick awakes he shakes his head.

NICK
What the hell? Warrior child. Uncle
Ahote and my mom.

Nick walks over to the front door and opens it to find the Elysium Times newspaper he brings it inside. Nick loses his balance for a moment.

NICK (cont'd)
Whoa.

Nick sits back down on the couch and begins to read the paper.

INT. LIVING ROOM - LATER

Nick is asleep on the couch with his dad pulling the newspaper from underneath Nick's arms. Nick begins to stir. Stephanie walks over and yanks the paper out.

STEPHANIE
Hello Sunshine.

NICK
Hey.

STEPHANIE
For your first day of vacation how
about you whip up some omelettes?

NICK
Fine.

Nick gets up and walks towards the kitchen. Stephanie grabs the paper from him.

STEPHANIE
Thanks for the paper bro. Oh yeah
Amanda from the ad agency called
yesterday. She needs some help.

NICK
Thanks. I'll call her later.

STEPHANIE
You would call your boss at the gas
station right away.

NICK
I'm sorry whose house do you live in?

STEPHANIE
Then give me the empty one.

NICK
Trying earning one.

STEPHANIE
In this economy!?!

Nick smiles and shakes his head.

STEPHANIE (cont'd)
Seriously...Alicia died three years ago. At least get rid of the house.

FRANK
Kids cut it out! Stephanie Ann read me the damn paper. Nicholas Bear--

Stephanie laughs.

STEPHANIE
Your middle name is bear.

FRANK
Stephanie!

Stephanie picks up the paper and opens it up.

STEPHANIE
Fine. What do you want me to start with?

FRANK
Start with the weather.

STEPHANIE
Elysium Center 82 uhm Neptune's Bay 75.

NICK
I think you flipped those.

STEPHANIE
What?... How did you know that?

NICK
I read it earlier this morning.

STEPHANIE
You think you're so smart. What's the temp in Paris?

NICK
55 low of 46

STEPHANIE
London, Geneva, Rio?

NICK
55 low of 39, 57 high 43 low and 82
and 72.

STEPHANIE
Did you read the whole paper?

NICK
Most of it.